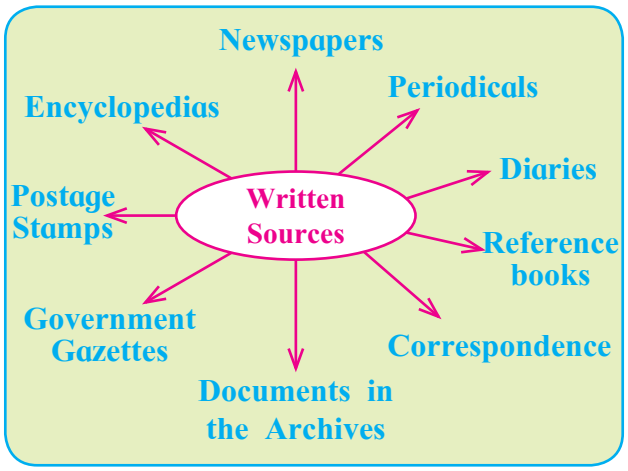
1 Sources of History

Till now we have studied the history of ancient, medieval and modern India. This year we have to study the history of India in the post-independence era. Sources of modern history are different from those of ancient and medieval history. We can study history with the help of various sources like written sources, material sources, oral sources and sources in the audio-visual medium. In the modern period, we have to take note of various sources at the regional, state, national as well as international level. We can write history with the help of these sources.

Written Sources : The following sources are included in the written sources.



Do you know?

The place where historical documents are preserved is called 'Archives'. The main office of the National Archives of India is at New Delhi. It is the largest among the Archives in Asia.

Just as newspapers are considered the fourth pillar of democracy in the modern period, they are also a major medium of information. If we consider the period from 1961 to 2000, we see that in the beginning, there was no alternative to the print media, especially newspapers. With liberalisation and widespread use of internet in India, an alternative for print media became available. Yet, the print media still continue to be powerful.

Newspapers : Through newspapers, we can get information about national and international affairs, politics, art, sports, literature and social and cultural affairs. Newspapers contain matters related to human life. Most national newspapers have started their regional editions. They publish supplements that give information about various topics. Newsletters of various movements, the dailies or weeklies of political parties, monthly and annual magazines are important among the print media.

Some newspapers produce special supplements towards the end of the year that take an overview of the important events of the year. Such supplements help us understand the important events of the year.

Press Trust of India (PTI) : After 1953, the Press Trust of India has been an important source of primary details of all important events and of articles on important subjects. Press Trust of India has provided reports, photographs and articles on financial and scientific issues to newspapers. PTI has now started its online service. During the 1990s, PTI started using the 'satellite broadcast' technology instead of tele-printers to send news all over the country. This material is important for writing the history of modern India.

Do you know?

Among the print media, the information contained in the annual issues of the Publications Division of the Government of India is authentic and trustworthy. For example, the Information and Broadcasting Department published **INDIA 2000**, an annual reference book. This reference book is created under 'Research, Reference and Training Department'.

It contains useful information about the land, its people, national emblems, political system, defence, education, cultural events and an account of the developments in the fields of science and technology, environment, health and family welfare, social welfare, media of mass communications along with basic data, related to economics, finance, planning, agriculture, water conservation, rural development, food and civil supplies, energy, industries, trade and commerce, transport, communication, labour, housing, laws and statutes, youth and sports departments, etc. It is possible for us to write history with the help of such information.

Website : *www.publicationsdivision.nic.in*

Postage Stamps : The postage stamps don't reveal anything on their own. Yet a historian makes them speak. There have been several changes in postage stamps since India became independent. Postage stamps reveal a lot to us about changing times due to the variety in the sizes of the stamps, the novelty in their subjects and colour schemes.

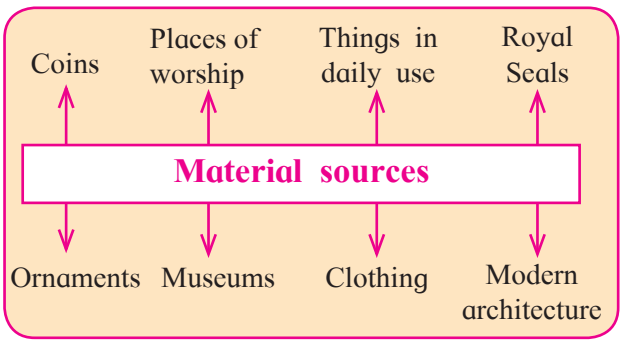
The Postal Department issues postage stamps on a wide variety of themes like political leaders, flowers, animals, birds, an event, or the silver, golden, diamond jubilees or centenary, bicentenary, tercentenary of different events. It is therefore a valuable repository of history.

Do you know?

The Indian government issued the 'Jal Cooper' stamp in 1977. Jal Cooper was an internationally acclaimed philatelist, i.e. an expert on the subject of 'postage stamps'. Born in a Parsi household in Mumbai, Cooper edited 'India's Stamp Journal'. He was the founder of the first Philatelic Bureau in India, an office that collected stamps. He founded the 'Empire of India Philatelic Society'. He went on to write many books on this subject. He gave a scientific bent to his hobby. He played a pivotal role in taking the study of Indian postage stamps to the international level. Having started his career as a postage stamp collector, Cooper achieved the expertise of a philatelist at the international level. The postage stamp on Jal Cooper is an important source to understand his significant contribution to this field.

Jal Cooper Postage Stamp

Material Sources : The following sources are included among the physical sources.



Coins : We can also understand history with the help of coins and the changes in the printing of currency notes. Reserve Bank of India prints the notes. It has its headquarters in Mumbai.

Coins

The coins from 1950 to those used at present, the metals used for making them, their different shapes, the diversity of subjects on them together help us to understand the important contemporary issues in India eg., coins to convey the message of population control and coins communicating the importance of agriculture and of farmers.

Museums : All States of India have museums that depict the characteristics and display the cultural and social heritage of the State. They enable us to understand history (eg., the Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Museum at Mumbai. Apart from the Government Museums, some private collectors also set up their own museums. They are based on distinctive subjects. eg., coins, notes, lamps and nutcrackers in different shapes, cricket equipment, etc.

Oral sources : These sources include folktales, folksongs, proverbs, ballads and *owis* (Marathi verses in the oral tradition). Activists were inspired by the *powadas* of Lokshahir Anna Bhau Sathe and Shahir Amar Sheikh during the Sanyukta Maharashtra Movement.

Try this.

As an example of how some event gets reflected in literature and how a poet perceives that event, study the poem 'Aavahan' written on the backdrop of the Sino-Indian war by the noted Marathi poet Kusumagraj.

Find pieces of literature based on contemporary events.

Audio-visual sources : Television, films, internet are called 'Audio-visual media'. Many domestic and foreign television channels also come under this head, eg., History channel, Discovery channel, etc.

Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) : The Government of India started the Film and Television Institute of India at Pune in 1960 with the purpose of providing public education. An institute called Indian News Review has produced various newsreels on important events in politics, social issues, art, sports and culture. This Department has also produced various documentaries on prominent social leaders, on people who have made major contributions for the country and about important locations in India. These news releases and documentaries are useful for studying the history of modern India.

FTII Logo

Try this.

Which films about patriotism do you know of? In your own words, write a review of one such film that you have liked.

Till now we have seen some important sources for writing the history of modern India. The times in the 21st century are changing so rapidly, that even these sources will prove to be inadequate. However, new sources are coming forth. For example, during the transformation from land line telephone to cellphones, a gadget called 'pager' came up for contacting people. But it died out as quickly as it had come up. The huge amount of information available on the Internet is used for studying history, but the truth and authenticity of this information needs to be verified.

Now it has become comparatively easy to study history with the all these sources. As these sources are from the contemporary period, they are easily available. Since a subject like history touches all the aspects of our lives, efforts for preservation of such sources are made at all levels. We should also contribute to this effort.

Exercises

1. (A) Choose the correct option from the given options and complete the statements.

(1) The National Archives of India is situated at.....
(a) Pune (b) New Delhi
(c) Kolkata (d) Hyderabad

(2) The ..... is included among the Audio-Visual media.
(a) Newspaper (b) Television
(c) All India Radio (d) Periodicals

(3) ..... is not included in physical sources.
(a) Coins (b) Ornaments
(c) Buildings (d) Proverbs

(B) Identify and write the wrong pair.

Person		Specialty
Jal Cooper	-	Philatelist
Kusumagraj	-	Poet
Anna Bhau Sathe	-	A people's bard
Amar Shaikh	-	Art collector

2. Write short notes on-

(1) Written Sources
(2) Press Trust of India

3. Explain the following statements with reasons.

(1) The postal department tries to preserve the heritage and integrity of Indian culture through postage stamps.
(2) Audio-visual media are an important source for writing the history of modern India.

Projects

(1) Create a handwritten account or a documentary about your school.
(2) Watch the different documentaries available on the official website of the Archeological Survey of India, an organisation under the Government of India.
(3) Which sources would you use to write the history of your village/town? Write the history of your village/town using those sources.

RLGQ5U